Sort Out What Is Actually Going Wrong With Your Father's Care

Four prompts to turn complaints into examples, find the tasks that are slipping, hear the caregiver who is running out of room, and decide who needs to hear what.

Where you are

Your father's care isn't working and everyone has a theory. Your sister, who does most of it, is exhausted and short with everyone. Phone calls turn into arguments about whose fault it is, and nobody can say exactly what is going wrong.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can name the real problems with an example for each, say which tasks are not getting done, state plainly what your sister needs, and know which concerns belong with a professional.

A one-page concerns list with four headings: What Is Going Wrong (one example each), What Is Not Getting Done, What the Caregiver Needs Now, and Who Should Hear About Each One.

Before you start

- The complaints you've heard, from anyone, in the words they used.
- A list of what has to happen for your father each week and who is supposed to do it.
- Ten minutes with your sister, or whoever carries the most, to ask what cannot go on. Any one of these is enough to start.

PROMPT 1

Turn the complaints into examples

WHY THIS MATTERS

'Nobody is looking after him properly' starts a fight. 'He missed his Tuesday appointment and no one knew until Thursday' starts a conversation. The difference is an example.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The concerns people have raised, written down as close to their words as you can.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the concerns my family has raised about my father's care, in the words people used:
>
> [PASTE THE CONCERNS]

> For each one, give me three lines: THE CONCERN AS STATED, A SPECIFIC EXAMPLE if one is in my notes (otherwise write “no example yet”), and WHAT KIND OF PROBLEM IT IS: care, communication, paperwork, or workload. Where a concern is aimed at a person, rewrite it as a description of what happened or didn't happen, without naming anyone as the cause. Keep every concern, even the ones that sound small.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many concerns have 'no example yet' beside them. Those need a fact before they need a meeting.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Go find an example for the two concerns that worry you most, or set them aside for now.

PROMPT 2

Find the tasks that are slipping

WHY THIS MATTERS

Care breaks down one task at a time. The prescription that didn't get picked up, the bill that didn't get paid, the shower that keeps getting skipped. A list of tasks and their actual status is more useful than a general sense that things are falling apart.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What needs to happen for your father in a normal week, and who you believe does each thing.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> This is what has to happen for my father each week and who I think handles it:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Make a table with columns: TASK, WHO IS SUPPOSED TO DO IT, LAST TIME IT HAPPENED AS FAR AS I KNOW, and STATUS (happening, not sure, or not happening). Then group the “not sure” and “not happening” rows into related clusters, for example everything about medications or everything about appointments. For anything involving medication, mark it “ask the pharmacist or doctor's office” and don't offer any advice about the medication itself. Don't rank the gaps by how serious they are.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The cluster with the most 'not sure' rows. That's where nobody has clear ownership.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Confirm the 'not sure' rows with whoever is supposed to be doing them. Ask, don't accuse.

PROMPT 3

Hear the caregiver before she stops talking

WHY THIS MATTERS

The person doing most of the work is often the last to be asked how she's doing and the first to be criticized. If your sister stops, everything stops. Her answer to 'what can't go on like this' is the most important information in this guide.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Her own words, from a conversation where you mostly listened.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I asked my sister, who does most of the day-to-day care for our father, what cannot continue the way it is. Here is what she said, as close to her words as I could get:
>
> [PASTE HER WORDS]
>
> Sort what she said into three lists: WHAT HAS TO CHANGE RIGHT AWAY, WHAT SHE CAN KEEP DOING FOR NOW, and WHAT SHE NEEDS FROM THE REST OF US. Keep her phrasing. Where she mentioned her own health, sleep, or job, put it in a fourth list called THINGS WE SHOULD TAKE SERIOUSLY and don't give advice about them. Then write three questions I could ask her to make sure I understood.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Whether 'what has to change right away' is longer than you expected.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the three lists back to her and ask what you got wrong.

PROMPT 4

Decide who needs to hear what

WHY THIS MATTERS

Not everything belongs in the family meeting, and not everything belongs with the doctor. Sorting the concerns by who should hear them stops one conversation from trying to carry everything.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your output from the three prompts above.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've worked out about the problems with my father's care:
>
> [PASTE YOUR OUTPUT FROM THE THREE PROMPTS ABOVE]
>
> Give me one page with four headings: WHAT IS GOING WRONG, with one example beside each item; WHAT IS NOT GETTING DONE; WHAT THE CAREGIVER NEEDS NOW; and WHO SHOULD HEAR ABOUT EACH ONE, where you tag every item as family, the doctor or nurse, the pharmacist, a care consultant, or not sure. Group related items so the page reads as a handful of problems, not a long list. Where family members described the same event differently, keep both accounts side by side. Do not suggest a solution for any of them.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page with fewer, clearer problems than you started with, and a name beside each one.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick the two items tagged 'family' to discuss first. Carry the page to the next step below.

Now let the interview find what you missed.

You've named the problems you can see. The care interview goes through your father's situation area by area, including the parts no one has complained about yet, and puts the whole picture into one Family Care Profile.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›